

What do you do when someone has the potential for the next level, but not the leadership behavior?

She could razzle-dazzle her way through almost any presentation. Accountability was another story.

- People Leadership
- Learning and Capability Expertise
- Career Progression



She wanted to be a Director.
She was creative. Smart. Emotionally persuasive. And an excellent presenter.



But when employees underperformed,
She absorbed the work instead of addressing the performance. She didn't document. She avoided the conversation. And weak behavior continued.



Then she asked to hire another person.
The new headcount would absorb what one of her underperforming managers wasn't completing. My answer was no. "This isn't a capacity problem. It's a performance problem."



I asked for the performance documentation.
There wasn't any. So I documented her performance gap. Not as a punitive measure - if she wanted to be an effective Director, she needed to understand that allowing poor performance to become normal was itself a failure of leadership.



Then we worked on it.
I modeled the conversations. We practiced. We worked through documentation. We practiced again.



Eventually, she successfully managed the employee out of the organization.
Her documentation went through HR and Legal without pushback.



And eventually,
She left Samsung. For a Director role at another company. We get together every time I'm in town.

AT A GLANCE



Talent
for the next level



Gaps
in accountability



No resource
increase approves



Promotion
achieved externally

WHY THIS STORY

Developing someone doesn't always mean making their path easier. Sometimes the most supportive thing I can do is hold the standard, have the difficult conversation, and give someone the opportunity to rise to it.

This story also demonstrates:

Performance leadership

Difficult conversations

Succession planning

Leadership judgement

Developing leaders

IF WE TALK, ASK ME ABOUT

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What I was looking for before I believed the behavior change was real.

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Where I draw the line between feedback and accountability.

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What I would have done if she still avoided the hard conversations.

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How I practice for difficult conversations.

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Why her leaving the company still feels like a win.

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What I look for to determine "coachability."

 WHAT I'M PROUD OF

I'm proud of her for accepting the feedback in the way it was intended - to support her career trajectory and personal growth. I'm proud of me for holding the boundary firm, while still being a compassionate leader.

 MY GUIDING PRINCIPLE

Documentation is not negative or positive - it just is. Humans forget things, and contemporaneous documentation ensures facts stay facts.

 IF I HAD A DO-OVER

I wouldn't take on as much of a helping role to her as I did in the beginning. Creating documentation templates and putting calendar reminders in showed it was a priority and that there were methods, but didn't shift the responsibility to document her team onto her shoulders.